

Big Ron Jackson

Chisox Secret Weapon Ready for Launching

NEW YORK, March 25 (AP)—Manager Al Lopez of the Chicago White Sox thinks his "secret weapon" is about ready for launching.

Ron Jackson, six feet, seven inches tall and weighing 240, is beginning to drop those home run bombs the White Sox have been expecting ever since they signed him for a \$25,000 bonus in 1954 as a junior at Western Michigan College.

If the kid from Kalamazoo finally delivers at first base, it couldn't happen at a better time. Lopez is desperate for distance since trading off Larry Doby and Minnie Minoso to strengthen his pitching.

From the day he took over the White Sox at the end of the 1956 season, patient Al has regarded Jackson as his power weapon of the future. Last spring and early this year, he regarded Ron with a dreamy look.

"When the kid finally makes it," he insisted, "we'll get the big power boost we need. Besides, he's too big to overlook."

Being big may have slowed Jackson's development, though the bonus rule in effect when he signed in '54, also held him back. He had to stick with the White Sox for two seasons before they were permitted to send him out to learn his trade by actual playing.

Ron hit .304 at Vancouver in 1956 and .310, with 21 homers, at Indianapolis last season. This spring, he banged his first homer off George Brunet of the Athletics and a pair off Harvey Haddix and Johnny Klippstein as he knocked in six runs in one game against Cincinnati.

Some bonus babies make it quick, some late and some never. Jackson appears to be in the middle category.

"I got stale sitting on the White Sox bench for two years," he admits. "I'm sure I could hit big league pitching if they'd let me play regularly."

But off what he showed with an average he sometimes had to fight to keep from sinking below .200, Jackson didn't get the chance from Marty Marion, then managing the White Sox. The next season, with a .214 average in 22 games, he was shipped to Vancouver the day his bonus term was up and there he began to find the range.

Determined to make it in the big leagues, Ron moved on to Indianapolis last year where he was belting the ball at .350 by mid-summer and

hitting homers of the "tape measure" variety. He finished with .310, 21 homers, 102 RBI's in 143 games.

There has been some doubt about Ron's fielding but Andy Cohen, who managed him at Indianapolis, insists he makes "a wonderful target for a throw and gets balls no other fellow could possibly reach."

Now 24 and getting bigger by the minute, Ron is a right-hander all the way.

This could be the year the White Sox start collecting royalties at last on that bonus of four years back.